RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO THE MISHNAH

Who Was the World Made For? Sages and the People of the Land

Rambam's Intro to the Mishnah, Part 8

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to the Commentary on the Mishnah (Rav Shilat's edition), section ז: why Hashem created so many who never pursue wisdom

Shiur: Part 8 (penultimate) of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to the Mishnah, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 8 July 2025

These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording.

Recap

Over seven classes: the Oral Torah; Sages vs prophets; the purpose, structure and order of the **Mishnah**; the **Talmud's** four purposes, the fourth being ***derashot***, which led the Rambam to the puzzling statement:

אין לו להקב״ה בעולמו אלא ארבע אמות של הלכה בלבד.

What can it mean? There **was no halachah** in the days of **Shem and Ever's yeshivah**, or Avraham. So the Rambam digressed into **the purpose of Earth** (not the whole universe): man-made things have obvious purposes; natural things serve **the human**, broadly speaking, and the wiser you are, the more of their purposes you grasp. **The human's purpose:** to fully develop **intellect** (all disciplines, culminating in knowing **Hashem**) and **character**. A person isn't complete without **both**.

The Question

> You said Divine wisdom makes nothing in vain; the most honoured creature on earth is man; man's purpose is the intellect. **Then why did Hashem create all the people who never develop it?** **ונשארה כאן שאלה אחת.**
>
> most people are **naked of wisdom**, chasing pleasures. **The wise, restrained person is a rarity, a marvel** one in many generations. **ואנחנו נמצא שרוב בני האדם ערומים מן החכמה, מבקשי תאוות: לא ימצא אלא אחד בדור מן הדורות,**

Clarifying the question

It isn't a question about people. Each person has **בחירה**, free will, which the Rambam calls **an עמוד גדול**, a great pillar of the Torah. That few choose this path is **the person's** problem.

It's a question about Hashem. If He made the Earth for **the perfected human**, and that person comes along once in generations, "**statistically, it doesn't seem to make sense.**"

Answer 1: The Others Make the Sage's Life Possible

מציאות כל אותם בני אדם לשתי סיבות. האחת, לשמש לאיש ההוא.

Their existence has two reasons. **First, to serve that one person.**

The Rambam is **"very pragmatic"**:

> **שאילו היו בני אדם כולם מבקשי החכמה ומתפלספים, היה העולם חרב והיה נכרת המין האנושי בזמן מועט.**
>
> **If everyone were a philosopher, the world would stop, and humanity wouldn't last long.**

Why? Humans are **deeply needy**:

To have…	You'd need to learn…
Bread	Ploughing, harvesting, threshing, grinding, cooking, baking, and making the tools
Clothes	Spinning and weaving
Shelter	Building, and all its tools

> **ולא יספיקו ימי מתושלח ללמוד אלו המלאכות.** Not even **Metushelach's 969 years** would be enough to learn them all. And when would you study?

So Hashem created everyone else to do that work: **תתיישב הארץ ותמצא החכמה**: the land is settled, **and** wisdom is found.

"If not for the madmen…"

A saying of the Rambam's time: **לולא המשוגעים היתה הארץ נחרבת**: *if not for the madmen, the world would be destroyed.*

A man, perhaps **not even strong**, **crosses the seas in winter** and **deserts in the summer heat**, exposed to **wild animals and creatures**, **for perhaps a dinar**. Then he hands his hard-won money to builders to lay deep foundations and raise **a wall to stand for centuries**, **knowing full well** he hasn't enough life left to wear out **a wall of reeds**. **"What greater folly could there be?"**

"Still true today, with different challenges: leaving your family, **planes**, exposure to illness, **Zoom meetings**, back and forth. To make money to build a mansion that will last a few hundred years, **which you'll never enjoy for a few hundred years.** In the grand scheme, it's ridiculous. **But we need it.** We need people to develop the land."

On a "learn-only" society

"It always bothered me: in some circles, **every boy** must go to yeshivah and **kollel** and **learn his whole life**, unless there are extenuating circumstances. **And then their *chachamim*, when ill, go to doctors; when they need legal advice, go to lawyers.** If everyone did what the rosh yeshivah said and studied all their lives, **where would the doctors, lawyers and builders come from?** You'd use the secular Jew, the one who only learns in the evening."

"**Long-term immersion in Torah and wisdom is amazing**, literally the pinnacle of creation. **But that's for a limited few. We need ordinary people to develop the world.**"

What *am ha'aretz* really means

ועל כן קוראים החכמים לאנשים אשר אין להם חכמה "עם הארץ", כלומר שהם עומדים לישוב הארץ.

"How beautiful." *Am ha'aretz* isn't simply "an ignoramus"; it means **"people of the land"**, those whose role is **to settle and develop the earth**: building, clothing, food. "**It's not a derogatory term.** They're a necessary part of creation."

When should everyone study? In the days of Mashiach, when everything will be provided. "From where we stand today it starts to make sense: **robots** are already taking humans' place in so many things."

Dov and Richard: is it all or nothing?

Isn't there a spectrum? Thousands are learned and fine people, not one-in-a-generation, but surely not just "general people"?

"**100%.** The Rambam talks in **extremities**. It's **not a zero-sum game**, as if you're either perfect or an *am ha'aretz*. There are millions of levels: 10%, 50%, 70%. **From the person's side**, each develops by his free choice, and dedicating yourself to study is wonderful. **From Hashem's side**, if the near-perfect person appears once in generations, why create everyone else? **Because some must be devoted to other things, to provide.**"

When the fool is served by the wise

ושמא יאמר אומר: sometimes **a foolish man**, rich through inheritance or luck, lives grandly, and **wise men work for him**. Isn't that backwards?

"You don't see the whole picture." In his wealth and power he commands a **great palace** or a **vast vineyard**, "like kings do."

One day a *chasid* will rest in that palace's shade and take delight in it, setting his mind right. **One day he'll find in that vineyard a remedy that saves him from a snakebite. כך הן הנהגות השם יתברך ויתרומם בחכמתו: עצות מרחוק אמונה אומן**.

Rav Kook in England was so taken with **Rembrandt's paintings** that he said (in words to the effect) the painter must have had **a spark of prophecy**.

Ben Zoma on the Temple Mount

בן זומא ראה אוכלוסין על גב מעלה בהר הבית, אמר: ברוך... שברא כל אלו לשמשני (Berachot 58a)

Seeing the throngs of pilgrims: *Blessed is He who created all these to serve me.*

"You hear that and think: **arrogant, narcissistic.**" **The Rambam:** he was **unique in his generation**, and his meaning is **gratitude**: *thank Hashem for a diverse humanity, people building homes, making clothes, growing food, so that I can devote myself to wisdom and character.*

What "serving the Sage" doesn't mean

"To be abundantly clear: the Rambam **strictly forbids** a *chacham* using Torah as **a spade to dig with**. **He'd have hated** the idea of simply supporting him." It means the world **develops the things** the Sage can then **acquire and use properly**. The legitimate links the Gemara allows: **doing business** with the Sage, or **marrying one's daughter** to him.

The Rambam on Bava Kamma

A law **"anti-Semites like to quote"**: if a Jew's ox gores a gentile's, in a place with **no set laws**, there's no liability. The Rambam's own **Commentary** there:

If their law favours them, we judge by their law. But where a society lacks **שלמות המדות האנושיות**, **the laws and norms between person and person that sustain human society**, its members **אינו בכלל האדם על האמת**: are not *adam* in the true sense. "This needs a discourse of its own."

The Rabbi's reading: consistent with tonight's theme, **a full *adam is one working on intellect and character. A society living without the basic values (the seven Noahide laws, courts and justice) has left the category of adam***.

Answer 2: Even the Sage Needs Company

אנשי החכמה הם מעטים מאוד. People of real wisdom are **very few**, and that's simply how reality is.

Don't ask why. The Rambam uses this logic often: it's like asking why there are **nine spheres** or **four elements** (fire, air, water, earth, as they believed then). In the **Moreh**: *why is the sky blue?* "If it were green, you'd ask why green."

Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai: ראיתי בני עלייה והן מועטין, אם שנים הן, אני ובני הן: *I've seen the people of ascent, and they are few; if there are two, they are my son and I.*

משום כך הומצאו ההמון להיות לחברה לאנשי המעלה.

The masses were created to be company for the people of excellence.

ואולי תחשוב שזאת התועלת מעוטה? אדרבה, חשובה היא. On the contrary, it matters. "Perhaps even more than the first" You may think this a small benefit.

His proofs:

- **Mishpatim: לא אגרשנו מפניך בשנה אחת, פן תהיה הארץ שממה**. Hashem wouldn't drive out the nations of Canaan all at once, **lest the land become desolate**.

- **Kohelet: סוף דבר הכל נשמע, את האלהים ירא ואת מצותיו שמור, כי זה כל האדם**. The Midrash: **the whole world was created only to be company for this one.**

A rabbi's memoir. "A famous American rabbi's community said at his retirement: *how will we cope without you?* He answered: ***more than you need me, I need you.*** **A rabbi without a community isn't a rabbi.** He can't give, can't influence, can't fulfil his potential."

Answer	Kind
1. To provide	**Pragmatic and physical**
2. To be company	**Emotional and social**: a life without people is **desolate and lonely**

Robert: *wouldn't a Sage rather have a few more Sages as friends?*

"Of course. But **that's not reality**: like the blue sky. **A person will take any company over loneliness.** Trust me, a rav would rather preach to an ignorant community that at least listens than have **no one on Shabbat morning**. **More than a rabbi gives his community, the community gives the rabbi.**"

"The Four Cubits of Halachah," Solved

הלכה comes from **הליכה**, **developing**: walking with Hashem, **walking**.

ילכו מחיל אל חיל; צדיקים אין להם מנוחה: growing always, **always walking**, the righteous have no rest.

אין לו להקב״ה בעולמו אלא ארבע אמות של הלכה: who all Hashem has in His world are **those who walk**, keep developing their intellect and character. **That is the purpose of creation.**

"**I can't tell you how many people have asked me: *why are you still studying? You've studied so many years, take a break!*** That's not how we think. **We never stop studying until the day we die.** Every day: what more can I learn, revise, study? **There's no end.**"

וכבר התבאר... כי תכלית כל מה שבעולם ההויה וההפסד איש שלם, כולל החכמה והמעשה.

The purpose of everything in this world of coming-to-be and passing-away is the complete person, who unites wisdom and deed.

וכבר יצאנו מענין זה, אשר נכנסנו בו מרוב אהבה: *I've strayed from the topic, out of great love.* **But these are fine matters of faith, not to be taken lightly.** "Now he comes back to the Talmud."

Questions

"Isn't a great Sage's soul a gift from God, not something he develops?"

"**No, absolutely not.** That's completely **antithetical** to the Rambam's philosophy. You're thinking of something **kabbalistic**, Chassidic stories of a holy neshamah coming down. **A person must choose this path.** We're **all born with deficiencies**, and we grow." *So anyone can become like Moshe Rabbeinu?* "The Rambam writes it **black and white**, in the Mishneh Torah (Hilchot Teshuvah, ch. 5): **every person can become like Moshe Rabbeinu.**"

Richard: so is everyone else's purpose to *support* the perfect person, or to *become* perfect, and are they failing?

"A **fantastic question**; it shows real depth. **It depends on whose perspective.**

- **From the person's:** your purpose is to aim for perfection. I wouldn't say *failed*, too harsh; you haven't **maximised your potential**. **None of us has**; we all know our failings.

- **From Hashem's:** He knows only one in a generation will reach it, and **creates everyone anyway**, because of **what they provide** for that person."

Summary

1. **The question is on Hashem, not man:** man has free will; but why create a world for the perfected person who comes once in generations?
2. **Answer 1: to provide.** If all were philosophers, the world would collapse; **not even Metushelach** could master every craft. **"If not for the madmen…" Am ha'aretz = "people of the land,"** who settle it; not a slur. Not everyone should learn all day: **who'd be the doctors?** Everyone studies **in Mashiach's days**.
3. **Even the fool served by the wise** ultimately serves the wise: the **palace a chasid will rest in**, the vineyard's **cure**. **Ben Zoma's blessing** is gratitude, not arrogance.

4. **Answer 2: company.** The wise are few (**"my son and I"**), as fixed as the four elements; **the masses exist to be their society**: **פן תהיה הארץ שממה; כי זה כל האדם**. **"More than you need me, I need you."**
5. **"The four cubits of halachah"** = those who **walk**, who never stop growing. **That** is all Hashem has in His world.
6. **Greatness is chosen, not gifted**; **anyone can be like Moshe**. We all fall short of our potential, yet **everyone has a purpose**.

Coming Up

Next week (the final class), or the week after: more principles of Talmud; the Rambam's teachers, **the Rif** and **Rabbi Yosef ibn Migash**; why his Commentary on the Mishnah is so foundational; and then something "**remarkable, before ChatGPT, before encyclopedias**": **ten short chapters listing the Sages of the Mishnah, their relationships, and how often each appears.**

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/GClVsQhLnlo · More shiurim: rabbikada.com